

MP3 PLAYERS

Flash-Based MP3 Players

iPod nano 8GB

Specifications

8 GB; second-generation, size: L x W x D = 3.5 x 1.6 x 0.3 inches; music formats supported: AAC, MP3, WAV, AIFF, Audible, Apple Lossless; Li-ion battery life: 16 hours

Our Verdict

The only second-generation nano available in pure, sinful black, the 8 GB iPod Nano now gets a scratch-resistant aluminium body while retaining that slim, sexy-as-hell look we've come to appreciate Apple's players for. It has a much brighter display (the same 1.5 inch) as

its predecessor: up to 40 per cent brighter. The new iPod is available in sizes of 2, 4, and 8 GB, and also gives up the curvy edges for a sharper look.

What remains unchanged is the excellent music quality. The thumbnail preview feature for viewing photos is neat. The only sore note with the 8 GB iPod Nano is the lack of video playback support, which some of the competitors provide. We're forgiving its inadequacies, though, for its great music performance and those hot looks!

Runner-Up: SanDisk Sansa e260



Hard Drive Based MP3 Players

iPod 80 GB

Specifications

80 GB; fifth-generation, size: L x W x D = 4.1 x 2.4 x 0.3 inches; audio standards supported: MP3, AAC, WAV, AIFF, Apple Lossless; Li-ion battery life: 20 hours under normal music playback

Our Verdict

Looks-wise, there are very subtle differences between the earlier iPods and this one. What has improved immensely is battery life during video playback. Apple's also provided a much

brighter screen, and provided a couple of desirable features such as gapless playback (between song tracks) and an instant search function.

Music playback, any portable player's bread and butter, are absolutely delicious on the iPod. The bundled earbuds could have been better, but they're comfortable thanks to silicone rims. It's a pity the body's still a scratch magnet, but once you plug it in, you'll forgive these little shortcomings.

Runner-Up: iPod 30 GB



OPTICAL DRIVES

Internal Optical Drives

Sony DRU-830A

Specifications

Write: DVD-R / +R: 18x; DVD+RW / +R DL / -R DL: 8x; DVD-RW: 6x; DVD-RAM: 12x; CD-R: 48x; CD-RW: 32x
Read: DVD-ROM: 16x; CD-ROM: 48x
USB 2.0; i.LINK FireWire; dimensions: 14.61 x 4.14 x 17.78 cm; weight: 0.91 kg

Our Verdict

The DRU-830A is capable of burning DVD+R and -R at breakneck speeds of 18x, the fastest around. It can even write at 18x to 16x media!

Dual-layer media can be burnt at 8x, which means you can burn a

complete dual-layer media in under 15 minutes.

Nero will take care of your burning, and the bundling of a black bezel means you can match the colour of your cabinet.

It has a 2 MB buffer and Ultra DMA33 interface and is cheaper than its competitors. It's the natural choice for the Zero1 Award for internal DVD-Writers.

Runner-Up: NA

